Indian voter is still attracted by the family name; the Nehru–Gandhi brand has a magnetic appeal in their bastion. But voters in Amethi are no different to their peers elsewhere and they can no longer be taken for granted by promises without delivery.

I never quite understood why UP's VIP constituencies like Amethi and Rae Bareli haven't seen greater progress. One only has to look towards the Pawar bastion of Baramati in Maharashtra to see what a VIP constituency can look like. In sharp contrast to Amethi, the Pawars had turned a sleepy village into a dynamic agro-industrial hub. The Gandhis clearly hadn't shown the entrepreneurial vision of the Pawars in transforming lives in a backward region.

Perhaps there was just something in the air of the Gangetic plain that retarded growth. It was almost as though the sharply polarized politics here had placed caste and community above vikas. Or maybe there were just well-entrenched interests and mafias committed to keeping the industry of backwardness alive and thriving. Certainly, the adversarial relationship between the state and Central governments didn't help. My own view is that the Gandhis, like many feudal politicians, were trapped in a *mai–baap* culture and that the odd public sector project can never be a substitute for long-term infrastructure (Amethi's roads are designed to rupture the backbone).

The BJP had sensed that the breeze of parivartan that was blowing through UP could, if not sweep, then certainly challenge, the Gandhi family dominance in this eastern UP pocket. For years, the Opposition had been accused of giving the Gandhis a soft landing in their pocket borough. Narendra Modi and Amit Shah were determined to change that perception.

Which is why the party dramatically announced the candidature of Smriti Irani from Amethi. A television soap star-turned-neta, the feisty and fearless Smriti was ready for a new role. Smriti had once spoken out against Modi on the Gujarat riots but then quite successfully (and uniquely, I might add) had been able to win him over. Modi liked Smriti's unflinching spirit and communication skills (I rather think he also saw her modern woman in a sari–sindoor image as a potential long-term counter to Sushma Swaraj